

FOOD AND DRINK

The basic Russian diet, grain, potatoes, oil, and sugar, tends to be fattening. Fresh fruit, vegetables, and meat are regarded as luxuries. In the last few years, however, increased food production and a better system of supply has led to a wider range of foods on sale in the big cities.



Vodka, a strong alcohol made from grain or potatoes, is the national drink. Alcoholism is a problem throughout Russia.



Sour cream

Borscht, a soup made from beetroot



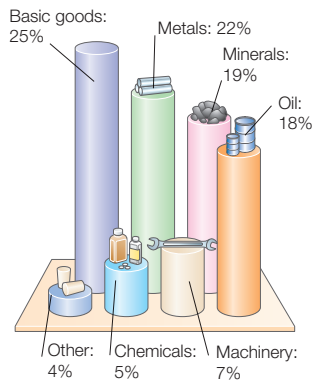
Black bread made from hard wheat



INDUSTRY

The former Soviet Union invested heavily in its industry. Vast industrial complexes were built in the iron-rich Ural Mountains and in the Kuzbass coalfield of southern Siberia. The production of coal, iron, and other minerals soared, and heavy industries, such as engineering, steel, iron, and chemical production, dominated the economy. However, Russia is now paying a price for this big advance. Many factories are old and inefficient, polluting the environment with harmful emissions.

Russian exports



THE MOSCOW SUBWAY

During the 1930s, the Soviet government built a huge underground railroad system beneath the streets of Moscow. The system is fast and efficient and is used daily by more than 7 million people. The stations were built deep down in the ground so that they could be used as air-raid shelters during wartime. Many are beautifully decorated with paintings, sculptures, and mosaics.



Well-known Western brands were sold quickly on the newly opened Russian market.

MARKET ECONOMY

When the USSR collapsed in 1991, the state-run, planned economy went with it. Switching abruptly to a liberal Western-style economy caused many problems for ordinary Russians, widening the gap between rich and poor. A severe crisis in 1998 was largely overcome, but Russia is still struggling to achieve Western-style prosperity.



This woman worker is helping clear heavy snow in Moscow.

WOMEN WORKERS

Many more Russian men than women died during World War II and in the labor camps set up by the Soviet leader Stalin. As a result, there are far more women than men in Russia, and women make up around 50 percent of the workforce. Good child care and medical services enable women with children to go out to work. Many work on the railroads or drive buses and streetcars. Most factories have large female workforces and many professions, such as medicine, dentistry, and teaching, are dominated by women.